United States Agency for International Development (USAID), at the project site in Jajarkot, which later became a Maoist stronghold.[11]

Bhattarai was also born in 1954, in Gorkha district in the hills, and, like Prachanda's parents, his parents also were bahun farmers. In 1970, he ranked first in the whole of Nepal in the School Leaving Certificate Exam of that year. He received further education in India, where he earned a Bachelors degree with honours in architecture from a university in Chandigarh and later a Ph.D. degree from the prestigious Jawaharlal Nehru University in New Delhi. His dissertation was titled *The Nature of Underdevelopment and Regional Structure of Nepal: A Marxist Analysis*.[12] While in India, he became the founding chairman of the All India Nepalese Students' Association.[13]

The road to armed rebellion they were going to tread on began when the powerful UPF split on the eve of the 1994 election. The main group, led by Bhattarai, decided to boycott the election while a smaller faction under Niranjan Govinda Vaidya participated but did not win a single seat—hence the assumption on the part of the authorities that the left was weak and divided, which turned out to be a monumental mistake.

After the first attacks in February 1996, the armed insurrection quickly spread to the neighbouring districts of Salyan, Jajarkot, and Kalikot, and soon to other parts of Nepal. The new slogan was much more militant than the relatively moderate rhetoric of the UPF, or even the Jhapa movement of the 1970s: 'War, war, and war! From the beginning to the end!'[14]

But having Peru's Shining Path as a role model did not endear the Nepalese Maoists to the Chinese. In December 1980, early risers in Lima began to find dead dogs hung from traffic lights and lampposts in the Peruvian capital. They were adorned with signs that read, 'Deng Xiaoping, Son of a Bitch!'[15] On 25 October 1989, car bombs exploded outside the Soviet and Chinese embassies in Lima in attacks that were attributed to the Shining Path, which believed that communist leaders in Moscow and Beijing had betrayed Marxism-Leninism. On 28 December 1992, Shining Path guerrillas detonated two more car bombs, this time outside Lima's Japanese and Chinese embassies. China was an obvious target for the Peruvian Maoists, and Peru's president at the time, Alberto Fujimori, was of Japanese descent and as such seen as a puppet of Japan's multinational corporations.